While the gesture was touching, it's always slightly concerning being carried on the shoulders of team-mates. There's a good chance of being dropped and with two Test matches still to play, it wouldn't have been a great way to get injured. The Mumbai team had also arranged for a send-off in the room adjoining our dressing room, which was particularly touching. The Mumbai Cricket Association secretary Nitin Dalal was also there and a cake was cut in my honour and all the players said a few words. A number of them turned emotional as they spoke, and some had tears in their eyes. It was all very moving.

That wasn't the only surprise at Lahli. Unbeknown to me, Anirudh had invited a few of my closest friends – Sameer Dighe, Faisal Momen and Jagdish Chavan – to watch the game. He had sent them tickets himself and also arranged for their accommodation. On the evening of the first day of the game, the local manager came up to me and said there was someone waiting to take a picture and it wouldn't take more than a minute. I stepped outside, ready to pose, only to see my friends grinning at me. It was a great feeling to see them in Lahli. They have all been by my side through good and bad and it was a pleasant surprise to have them around me for my last domestic game.

Winning that Ranji Trophy match meant I had won all my final matches in every format of the game so far. It was a record I was extremely proud of and I hoped I would be able to keep it intact in my final series for India. Lahli had served as good preparation. Now I was looking forward to my penultimate Test match in Kolkata.

Farewell Eden Gardens

Having relaxed for a couple of days at home in Mumbai, and having visited the temples in Mumbai and Goa that I always visit to seek the blessings of God, I arrived in Kolkata on the evening of 3 November 2013. As always, Dwarkanath and Kalpa Sanzgiri had sent me ladoos (a type of Indian sweet) on the eve of the series to wish me luck. There was a mini welcome ceremony arranged by the Cricket Association of Bengal at the airport and there were a lot of people inside the terminal to receive me. In fact, the police were finding it very difficult to control the crowd and I had to hurry into the lounge to give them time to calm things down.

The situation showed no signs of improving in the next half an hour and I realized that the longer I waited, the more difficult it would be for